outraged in 2014 when it learned that he lunched at Fresco by Scotto, an excellent but decidedly un-kosher Italian restaurant in midtown Manhattan; one newspaper called it the “pig restaurant”. (He had the veal chops, according to the *New York Post*.) He was forced to explain himself in a television interview the following week, telling Channel 2 that, while he occasionally dines in non-kosher restaurants, “I don’t eat non-kosher foods.”

But for the railway, a crucial piece of infrastructure in a modern state, the ultra-Orthodox made a quiet exception—until September. The nature of the work made it harder to ignore: the Tel Aviv project wasn’t an isolated track repair, after all, but a major logistical operation in the heart of the country. Mostly, though, they spoke up because their constituents did. *Haredi* journalists started to complain about the Shabbat desecration, aiming their criticism not only at Katz and the transport ministry, but also the ultra-Orthodox parties, which they accused of enabling him. The debate started on Twitter, an increasingly popular medium in the ultra-Orthodox world. “Bibi thinks that the *haredim* are stupid,” wrote Beni Rabinovich, a writer at *Yated Ne’eman*, a daily ultra-Orthodox newspaper. “I hope the *haredi* parties know how to collect a political price tag from Yisrael Katz,” said Arye Erlich, the deputy editor of *Mishpacha*. A third columnist, Ya’akov Rivlin, argued that the ultra-Orthodox parties were desperately trying to avoid a political crisis because they feared leaving the government. “Shabbat is a political pawn,” he concluded.

The politicians quickly fell in line. They asked for a meeting with Netanyahu, and warned him that any further construction would force them to leave the coalition. The prime minister, in his usual indecisive fashion, dawdled until the last possible moment—Friday afternoon, 2 September, less than an hour before the start of Shabbat. Then he canceled the maintenance. His decision took the railway by surprise: workers had already started to dismantle sections of track, which meant the trains would be out of service when the day of rest ended. They went home for an unexpected dinner with their families.

So the rail line between Tel Aviv and Haifa was shut during the Sunday rush, with predictable results. Netanyahu’s decree inconvenienced a large chunk of the country, and it cost the railway more than $3 million, mostly in the form of lost revenue and compensation paid to the workers who had been scheduled for Saturday. And it didn’t even prevent Shabbat